Why Exchange Place is an insult: By being so slick, so special, ...
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Why Exchange Place is an insult

By being so slick, so special, sculpture-building disrupts the sense of place in Boston.

By ROBERT CAMPBELL

Exchange Place, the new mirror-glass office tower designed for Olympia & York developers by WZMH Habib, is not good architecture or good city-making, although its glittery pizzazz can be momentarily seductive.

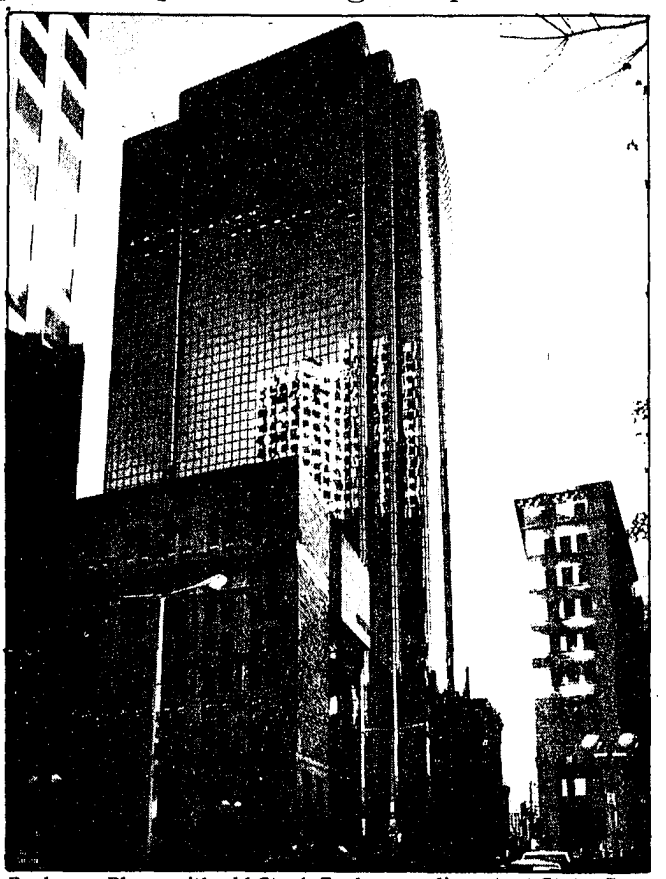
The seductiveness, in fact, is the problem with buildings like Exchange Place. They are spectacular enough to make you perceive them not in the way you should – as pieces that ought to enrich and complete the jigsaw puzzle of cityscape around them – but rather as isolated objects, as if they weren't buildings at all but only huge sculptures at building scale.

Look-at-me sculpture-buildings of Exchange Place's type have sprouted recently in many cities, notably Chicago and Houston. They can be very beautiful as objects or they can be tacky, but in neither case do they combine with one another and with older buildings into a sociable cityscape. They don't want to be part of the urban chorus, they want to be stars.

Exchange Place, as a matter of fact, is more than antisocial, it's actively insulting to most of the older architecture around it because it makes the richly textured and detailed masonry buildings of Boston look shabby by comparison with itself. That isn't because they really are shabby. It's because Exchange Place is trying to be too slick.

By being so slick, so special, Exchange Place disrupts the sense of place in Boston. Just as San Francisco, ideally, is a white city in a mist, so central Boston is a warm-gray to reddish-brown city of brick and stone. When you add to Boston more buildings of a Bostonian character, you make the city a more pungently individual place. When, on the other hand – like the developers and architects of Exchange Place – you choose to stand out like a glitter-punk adolescent at a Friday afternoon Symphony concert, you make the whole city less intensely itself. By making your building special, you make the city less special. You subvert one of architecture's greatest virtues, its ability to make one place recognizably different from another.

Exchange Place also makes the city less coherent. The most prominent buildings in a coherent city are not packages of leased office-space like Exchange Place. They are the railroad station, the art museum, the city hall, major buildings that are properly allowed to upstage their surroundings. Office buildings, however large, needn't seek, as Exchange Place does, to upstage everything around them.



Exchange Place, with old Stock Exchange adjacent, at State, Congress and Kilby streets in the Financial District.

The next problem with Exchange Place is its treatment of the adjacent Stock Exchange building, a turn-of-the-century landmark by the architects Peabody & Sterns. There was a long and fierce battle between the preservation community and the developers of Exchange Place, who originally proposed to demolish the Exchange. The battle ended in a compromise: The front of the Stock Exchange would be kept and the rear would be lopped off to create a site for the new glass tower. New tower and old landmark would be yoked violently together by a common atrium lobby.

The compromise wasn't bad in itself, and it accurately recorded the state of play between the forces of preservation and those of development on the battlefield of downtown Boston at that moment. Collages of this kind between new and old can be very rich, but not, unfortunately, here. Exchange Place as realized makes the original compromise seem absurd. Tower and landmark come from different planets. They do nothing for each other. At the common lobby, nothing seems even to be in the right place. The wing staircase that once graced the Stock Exchange, for instance, and which looked so grand in its original location on axis with the old building's entrance, has been lifted up, rotated 90 degrees, and dropped in a place where it leads nowhere and looks like a part of a set design in process of being dismantled. All authenticity is lost.

The next problem is Exchange Place's vanity. The entrance, far too palatial, is up a flight of outdoor steps into a gargantuan lobby featuring trees, a fountain, stainless steel columns, reflecting ceilings, floors of granite and patterned carpet, a space-frame construction, dark glass walls – in short, just about everything. It adds up to depressing chaos. The noted historian James Marston Fitch has noted that because modern architects didn't allow themselves to use lavishly expensive ornament, the only way they could display the wealth and power of their clients was through conspicuous consumption of empty but costly volumes of air at the ground level of their office towers. Hence the useless plazas and grandiose lobbies of such buildings as Exchange Place.

The next problem is detailing. The same little black-framed square of glass, multiplied ad infinitum, makes up the entire exterior of the building. No doubt the squares are economical, but Exchange Place suffers. It looked, in fact, much handsomer while it was still under construction, when many of the squares were as yet unglazed and the building sported not one but two materials. Now the little glass squares, spreading like mange over everything, even climb down the building's structural columns all the way to the sidewalk. Every opportunity for creating variety has been resolutely ignored.

At street level, the glass squares are blank and depressing. Despite some retail space (as yet unoccupied), the general impact of Exchange Place on the sidewalks around it is deadening. Much of the south front is killed by truck docks. And the glass skin absorbs more light than the masonry surfaces of older buildings, which tend to reflect light (at least when they're clean) and thus help illuminate the street.

Exchange Place does have one virtue. As long as you keep your eyes off the street and up on the skyline, the curving setbacks give the tower a handsome profile from many points of view. And they create marvelous bay-windowed offices inside. They even take some – although by no means enough – of the curse of hugeness off the tower by modulating its bulk. But Exchange Place remains the bulkiest, visually, of new downtown buildings, the fault not of its creators but of a city that as yet still refuses to plan its own future by setting firm guidelines.

Such guidelines are now promised and will, one trusts, deal with height, with materials, with stepbacks to let light into the street and to baffle winds, and with all the other issues of which Exchange Place offers so negative an illustration. This is, we may hope, a transitional building.

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